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Europe's military mobility plans have a workforce problem

By Martina Sapio · Sep 9, 2026, 4:42 PM · [View in your browser](#)

BRUSSELS — The EU's military mobility plans have a gaping hole — the workers needed to drive its trucks, run its trains and operate its ports in wartime.

The European Commission's proposed Military Mobility Regulation would let governments temporarily requisition civilian trucks, trains, buses, vessels and other transport assets — giving military traffic priority in an emergency.

But the regulation does not say who would drive the trucks, run the trains or crew the ships. It appears to assume civilian workers would do so, but that is never made clear. National governments can draft people into their militaries, but the legislation doesn't mention that.

"The framework currently pretends that there are enough drivers available, enough military personnel available everywhere to do these kinds of military-logistics services," said Felix Kraft, policy adviser at the European logistics association Clecat. "But that's not true."

That silence lands on a workforce that's already stretched thin. Road freight alone has roughly 502,000 unfilled driver jobs, according to a report by the International Road Transport Union. This gap would widen in wartime as drivers could face recruitment to drive military cargos while also being needed to keep food, medicine and fuel moving.

"It is a disaster waiting to happen," Kraft said. "We already have a scarce workforce, and we will have an even scarcer workforce during an emergency because these people will be needed elsewhere."

Livia Spera, secretary-general of the European Transport Workers' Federation, said the shortage is one of the sector's central vulnerabilities — and one Brussels has never properly addressed.

"There are shortages in infrastructure and coordination between member countries," she said. "But it has never been recognized as one of the fundamental issues."

For Cristina Scarfia, head of European affairs at Italy's freight federation Confetra, the problem is even broader. The regulation, she said, is aimed at using civilian infrastructure like roads, rail, ports and bridges, to ship troops, fuel and ammunition, but those same assets are also needed for civilian supply chains.

"You're asking civilian logistics to put itself completely at the disposal of military logistics," Scarfia said. Without enough support for operators, she added, the regulation could end up effectively destroying the civilian economy during a military crisis.

“Drivers aren’t the only people who are at risk here,” Kraft said. “It’s the entire transport and logistics sector on the ground.”

Troops and trains

The proposed regulation aims to remove red tape that can slow military transport and make it easier for convoys to cross borders.

It would also create an emergency system called the European Military Mobility Enhanced Response System. If activated, military transport would receive priority on roads, railways, at ports and at airports. Civilian trains could be delayed, ships could lose access to berths and other transport operations could be interrupted or postponed.

The proposal is now being negotiated by the European Parliament and the Council. But even its draft amendments don’t set out a framework for the workers who operate those assets or provide associated services, including driving, loading, refueling and repairs.

“The proposal includes infrastructure, transport assets and related equipment,” Kraft said. “But it does not include services. That’s where the workers come into play.”

Brussels has taken broader steps to address labor shortages, but none specifically addresses the workforce needs of a military emergency. Trade unions have put forward a more detailed wish list, asking countries to draw up emergency plans together with labor; it would cover training, staffing, safety, compensation and working conditions and also bar the automatic requisitioning of workers alongside civilian assets while protecting workers’ right to refuse military transport or high-risk assignments.

NATO recognizes that civilian workers need specialized training to move military cargo safely, Spera said. But high turnover in the transport sector, among other problems, makes it difficult for companies to retain the people they train.

“If you’re planning for military mobility,” she said, “you also have to plan for the workforce.”

Spera pointed to Ukraine as a preview of what’s at stake in case of war.

Since Russia’s full-scale invasion over four years ago, Ukraine’s railways have carried troops and military supplies alongside civilians and commercial freight. With no functioning commercial airports, the rail network is indispensable — and increasingly targeted. Russian forces have hit it more than 1,500 times so far this year, according to rail operator Ukrzaliznytsia — more than in all of 2025 — killing railway workers in strikes on stations, depots and moving trains.

“In Ukraine, workers have died,” Spera said. “They’re handling dangerous cargo, in sensitive infrastructure — what you’d call sensitive targets.”

Ukraine’s increasingly successful campaign to target Russian trucks in the occupied east of the country, disrupting logistics and killing drivers, also highlights the risks to civilians of getting caught up in war.

The issue may be largely missing from the EU framework, but national capitals are paying attention. Whether civilian workers can be compelled to serve in the armed forces — and continue operating transport assets as military personnel — is governed by national law.

POLITICO asked defense and transport ministries across the EU whether they had planned for a shortage of transport workers — and found broad agreement that the issue is a problem.

Several countries — including Estonia, Lithuania, Croatia, Latvia, Austria, Romania and Luxembourg — acknowledged the shortage. Some recognized that the military and civilian economy would end up competing for the same drivers, vehicles and transport facilities in a crisis, making it harder to move troops quickly while still keeping food, fuel and medicine moving.

Other countries are already making plans.

The Netherlands said it's going to give more military logistics work to companies that can guarantee enough vehicles and staff between 2027 and 2034. Germany has made it easier to train new truck drivers and created a nationwide list of transport companies ready to support the public, the economy and the armed forces in a crisis.

Missing in action

But the ongoing driver shortage is only part of a wider problem; the IRU says around 660,500 European drivers are expected to retire by 2030. 37.4 percent of EU transport workers are aged 50 to 64, according to Eurostat. Long stretches away from home, poor rest facilities, unpredictable schedules and difficult working conditions make recruitment difficult.

It's not just truck drivers. A study commissioned by the European Parliament found labor shortages were worsening across road, rail, maritime, inland-waterway and air transport alike, although the severity of the issue varies by mode.

Europe's transport workforce is also overwhelmingly male and drawn heavily from Central and Eastern Europe. Men made up 82.7 percent of EU transport workers, according to Eurostat, and cross-border road freight relies especially on Polish and Lithuanian drivers. A study found that 66 percent of certificates issued for drivers working in multiple EU countries originated from Poland and 18 percent from Lithuania.

That combination — an aging, male workforce concentrated in the frontline states that any war with Russia would hit first — is a problem for military mobility.

"We already don't have enough drivers," Kraft said. "If we imagine an armed conflict, many of the male drivers would be drawn into the military."

"We know what happened during Covid," Spera said. Transport workers kept supply chains running while governments, employers and unions scrambled after the fact to negotiate health protections and pay.

"This time, we're preparing in advance," she said. "So those contingency plans should also be negotiated in advance."

Spera wants governments, employers and unions to agree in advance on worker training, safety, compensation and working arrangements in an emergency — and to limit powers of the military mobility emergency rules to suspend driving and rest rules while prioritizing military traffic to narrowly defined circumstances.

"You can requisition a truck," Kraft said. "But someone still has to drive it."

Mobility Defense

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